from the contextual menu. We'll take a closer look at this project file in the next section.

Your project folder contains a subfolder called Properties, which contains a single file: launchSettings.json. This file controls how Visual Studio will run and debug the application. Visual Studio shows the file as a special node in Solution Explorer, out of alphabetical order, near the top of your project. You've got two more special nodes in the project, Dependencies and Connected Services, but they don't have corresponding folders on disk. Instead, they show a collection of all the dependencies, such as NuGet packages, and remote services that the project relies on.

In the root of your project folder, you'll find two JSON files: appsettings.json and appsettings.Development.json. These files provide configuration settings that are used at runtime to control the behavior of your app.

Finally, Visual Studio shows one C# file in the project folder: Program.cs. In section 3.6 you'll see how this file configures and runs your application.

3.5 The .csproj project file: Declaring your dependencies

The .csproj file is the project file for .NET applications and contains the details required for the .NET tooling to build your project. It defines the type of project being built (web app, console app, or library), which platform the project targets (.NET Core 3.1, .NET 7 and so on), and which NuGet packages the project depends on.

The project file has been a mainstay of .NET applications, but in ASP.NET Core it has had a facelift to make it easier to read and edit. These changes include

- *No GUIDs*—Previously, globally unique identifiers (GUIDs) were used for many things, but now they're rarely used in the project file.